Taliban militants, including perhaps one-eyed Afghan Mullah Omar himself, as well as Balochi separatists.

General Musharraf was eager to win reelection as president in 2007, but feared that Chief Justice Iftikhar Mohammed Chaudhry might try to prevent him from doing so as long as he retained his uniform as chief of army staff. The courageous chief justice, moreover, had issued legal orders to release many innocent Pakistanis held without cause by police, so Musharraf decided to fire him in March 2007, charging Chaudhry with corruption. This autocratic act provoked immediate uproars from Pakistan's prestigious bar associations, first in Lahore, then in Karachi and Islamabad, with thousands of irate, well-attired lawyers, trained to follow in Barrister Jinnah's fearless footsteps, marching in outraged protests provoked by the general's arrogant attempt to decapitate their Supreme Court.

The increasingly popular lawyers' protest marches that followed Musharraf's reckless act proved so effective in spearheading opposition to martial rule that it soon became clear, even to Musharraf himself, that elective civil government must be restored or Pakistan would face civil war and imminent collapse. So Musharraf met with Benazir Bhutto in Dubai, reaching a power-sharing agreement with her that would have allowed him to retain the position of president provided he surrendered his uniform. Benazir had earlier met and reached agreement with Nawaz Sharif in London, even signing a democratic elective accord with him that seemed far more promising, but, unfortunately, was then abandoned by her. Their old antipathy was never to be reconciled. Benazir distrusted Nawaz, and she thought she would have greater freedom to do as she liked working with Musharraf, but she thus left herself at the mercy of the army.

In September 2007, thousands of angry lawyers rallied to march through Islamabad, shouting, "Go, Musharraf, go!" The general still hoped, however, to hang on for another five years as Pakistan's president, and he was reelected October 6, even though he retained his uniform. Twelve days later, Benazir flew home to Karachi after eight years in exile, following Musharraf's grant of immunity to her and her husband, Asif Ali Zardari, which canceled all charges of corruption and murder previously posted against them. Millions of cheering admirers welcomed Benazir home, but the crowd was so huge, and her procession moved so slowly, that night fell before she could reach her Karachi beach house. Then the streetlights went out, and two bombs exploded